Phase 9: Meet Jesus!

The four Gospels, Matthew, Mark, Luke and John: four true books, one amazing Jesus. The King the whole Old Testament was waiting for has come!

At a Glance

Month	Month 9
Books covered	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John (**4 books**)
Bible section(s)	Gospels (the first section of the New Testament)
Big Idea	Jesus is the promised King, the Servant who came to help and to save, the Savior for everyone, and God's own Son. He died for our sins and rose again!
Memory Verse (all ages)	"For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"For God so loved the world." (John 3:16)
Theme color	Sunrise Gold (for the Light of the World and the first Easter morning)
Phase symbol / badge	✝️ The Empty Cross with a sunrise, "I Met Jesus!" badge with four corner icons (crown, running sandals, open arms, heart)
Running total of books learned	**43 of 66** (all 39 Old Testament books + 4 Gospels)

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 9 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

Remember the long, quiet bridge of 400 years? Now we've crossed it, and **Jesus is here!** The word **Gospel** means **"Good News."** Four writers, Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, each wrote a true book about Jesus' life. Jesus taught about God, healed sick people, calmed a storm, loved people nobody else loved, died on the cross for our sins, and came back to life on the third day!

How this points to Jesus: These books don't just point to Jesus. They show Him to us face to face! Everything the Old Testament promised comes true here: born in Bethlehem (Micah), the messenger John the Baptist (Malachi), the King on a donkey (Zechariah), the Servant pierced for our sins (Isaiah), three days like Jonah, and the Son of Man (Daniel). John tells us why the Gospels were written: "that you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (John 20:31).

The Books in Easy Words

> **Four Gospels, one Jesus.** Imagine four people watching the same soccer game from four different seats. One notices the coach, one notices the fast plays, one notices the fans, and one notices the star player's heart. They tell the same true game in four ways. That's like the four Gospels! Each one shows Jesus from a different "seat."
>
> **Teacher note:** Matthew, Mark and Luke are called the **Synoptic Gospels** ("seeing together") because they share many of the same stories in a similar order. John is different: about 90% of John's material is not found in the other three.

1. Matthew 👑

How to say it	MATH-yoo
How to spell it	Mat-thew — **M-A-T-T-H-E-W** (tip: double T, then "HEW." "MAT-THEW." Say "mat" + "thew.")
Section	Gospels (1 of 4), the first book of the New Testament
Traditional author	Matthew (also called Levi), a tax collector who became one of Jesus' twelve disciples (Matthew 9:9; Mark 2:14)
One-sentence kid summary	Matthew shows that Jesus is the promised King from David's family, the one all the Old Testament promises were about.
In one word	**King**
Key people	Jesus, Mary, Joseph, the wise men (Magi), King Herod, John the Baptist, Peter and the twelve disciples
Key stories	Jesus' family tree from Abraham and David (ch. 1); the wise men follow the star (ch. 2); the Sermon on the Mount, with the Beatitudes, "You are the light of the world," the Lord's Prayer, and the wise and foolish builders (ch. 5–7); Peter walks on water (ch. 14); Palm Sunday (ch. 21); the cross and the empty tomb (ch. 27–28); the Great Commission: "Go and make disciples of all nations" (28:18–20)
Where Jesus shows up	Everywhere! Matthew says over and over, "This happened to fulfill what the Lord had said through the prophet..." Matthew begins with Jesus as **Immanuel, "God with us"** (1:23), and ends with Jesus saying, **"I am with you always"** (28:20).
Hand motion / symbol	👑 **Bow to the King**: kneel on one knee and bow your head like the wise men: "Jesus is KING!"

2. Mark 🏃

How to say it	MARK
How to spell it	Mark — **M-A-R-K** (tip: the same as a marker! "On your MARK, get set, GO!")
Section	Gospels (2 of 4)

Traditional author	John Mark, a helper of Peter (1 Peter 5:13) and Paul (2 Timothy 4:11), cousin of Barnabas (Colossians 4:10). Early Christians said Mark wrote down Peter's eyewitness preaching.
One-sentence kid summary	Mark is the shortest, fastest Gospel, full of action, showing Jesus as the powerful Servant who came to help people and give His life for us.
In one word	**Servant** (in action!)
Key people	Jesus, John the Baptist, Peter, James and John, the paralyzed man and his four friends, the Roman centurion
Key stories	Starts fast with John the Baptist and Jesus' baptism (ch. 1); four friends lower a man through a roof (ch. 2); Jesus calms the storm: "Quiet! Be still!" (ch. 4); Jesus heals a girl and a sick woman (ch. 5); feeding the 5,000 (ch. 6); "Let the little children come to me" (ch. 10); the cross: "Surely this man was the Son of God!" (ch. 15); the empty tomb (ch. 16)
Where Jesus shows up	The key verse: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). Mark opens by quoting Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3 about the messenger (1:2–3), which links the two Testaments!
Hand motion / symbol	🏃 **Run in place**: pump your arms and shout "IMMEDIATELY!" (Mark uses the word "immediately" or "at once" again and again.)

3. Luke 🩺

How to say it	LUKE (rhymes with "duke" and "nuke," not with "book")
How to spell it	Luke — **L-U-K-E** (tip: a silent E at the end, just like "cute")
Section	Gospels (3 of 4)
Traditional author	Luke, "the doctor" (Colossians 4:14), a traveling partner of Paul. He also wrote **Acts**! He carefully interviewed eyewitnesses (Luke 1:1–4) and wrote to a man named Theophilus.
One-sentence kid summary	Doctor Luke carefully wrote down the true story of Jesus, the Savior who came for everyone, especially the lost, the poor, the sick and the left-out.
In one word	**Savior** (for everyone!)
Key people	Jesus, Mary, Zechariah and Elizabeth, John the Baptist, the shepherds, Simeon and Anna, Mary and Martha, Zacchaeus, the thief on the cross, two travelers to Emmaus
Key stories	Angel Gabriel visits Zechariah and Mary (ch. 1); Jesus born in Bethlehem, with angels and shepherds (ch. 2); 12-year-old Jesus in the temple (ch. 2); the Good Samaritan (ch. 10); the lost sheep, lost coin and lost son (ch. 15); ten lepers healed, one says thank you (ch. 17); Zacchaeus climbs a tree (ch. 19); the cross and the thief: "Today you will be with me in paradise" (ch. 23); the walk to Emmaus (ch. 24)
Where Jesus shows up	Luke's key verse: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (Luke 19:10). The angel announces: "Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord" (2:11). On the Emmaus road, Jesus explained how all the Old Testament was about Him (24:27, 44).
Hand motion / symbol	🤗 **Open arms wide**: "Jesus came for EVERYONE!" (or pretend to listen with a doctor's stethoscope).

4. John ❤️

How to say it	JON
How to spell it	John — **J-O-H-N** (tip: the H is silent! J-O-**H**-N. "Jo-(shh)-n.")
Section	Gospels (4 of 4)
Traditional author	John, son of Zebedee, a fisherman, brother of James, and one of Jesus' closest friends. He calls himself "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 21:20–24). Traditionally he also wrote 1, 2 and 3 John and Revelation.
One-sentence kid summary	John shows us that Jesus is God's own Son, who came from heaven so that everyone who believes in Him can have life forever.
In one word	**Believe** (Jesus is God's Son)
Key people	Jesus, John the Baptist, Nicodemus, the woman at the well, Mary, Martha and Lazarus, Thomas, Peter, Mary Magdalene
Key stories	"In the beginning was the Word" (ch. 1); water into wine at a wedding (ch. 2); Nicodemus at night and John 3:16 (ch. 3); the woman at the well (ch. 4); feeding the 5,000 and "I am the bread of life" (ch. 6); the man born blind (ch. 9); the Good Shepherd (ch. 10); Lazarus raised from the dead (ch. 11); Jesus washes His disciples' feet (ch. 13); the cross: "It is finished" (ch. 19); Mary Magdalene and Thomas see the risen Jesus (ch. 20); breakfast on the beach (ch. 21)
Where Jesus shows up	John is built around **7 signs** (miracles) and **7 "I AM" sayings**: "I am the bread of life," "the light of the world," "the gate," "the good shepherd," "the resurrection and the life," "the way and the truth and the life," and "the true vine." Thomas's words say it all: "My Lord and my God!" (20:28)
Hand motion / symbol	🌍 **World hug**: draw a big circle in the air (the world), then cross your arms over your heart: "For God so LOVED the world!"

Section summary: The Gospels (4)

#	Book	One word	Shows Jesus as…	Motion
1	Matthew	King	The promised King	Kneel and bow like the wise men
2	Mark	Servant	The Servant in action	Run in place, "Immediately!"
3	Luke	Savior	The Savior for everyone	Open arms wide
4	John	Believe	God's Son	Draw a big world, cross arms over heart

> **Fun teacher fact:** Since the early church, Christians have matched the Gospels with the four living creatures of Ezekiel 1 and Revelation 4 (human, lion, ox, eagle). The most common pairing (from Jerome) is Matthew = human, Mark = lion, Luke = ox, John = eagle. You'll see these symbols in old church art and stained glass. They're tradition, not Scripture, but they can be a fun "spot the symbol" activity!

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

What is a Gospel? "Gospel" (Greek *euangelion*) means "good news." Each Gospel is a theological biography: a true account of Jesus' life, death and resurrection, shaped to show who Jesus is and why it matters. They aren't a complete diary (John 21:25 says the world couldn't hold all the books!); each writer selected stories for his readers.

Gospel	Likely first readers	Emphasis	Length	Unique highlights
Matthew	Jewish Christians	Jesus the promised Messiah-King; fulfillment of the Old Testament; Jesus' teaching (five big teaching sections)	28 ch.	Wise men, flight to Egypt, Sermon on the Mount (full), Peter walks on water, Great Commission
Mark	Roman / Gentile Christians	Jesus the powerful, suffering Servant; fast-paced action; discipleship includes the cross	16 ch. (shortest)	Fast pace ("immediately"), Jesus' emotions, the centurion's confession
Luke	Theophilus and Gentile readers	Jesus the Savior of all; careful history; outsiders, women, the poor, prayer, the Holy Spirit	24 ch. (longest book in the NT)	Birth of John, shepherds, boy Jesus, Good Samaritan, Lost Son, Zacchaeus, Emmaus
John	Christians and seekers everywhere	Jesus the eternal Son of God; believing in Him brings eternal life	21 ch.	Seven signs, seven "I AM" sayings, Nicodemus, the woman at the well, Lazarus, foot-washing, Thomas

Timeline & map notes.

- Jesus was born **about 6–4 B.C.** (before Herod the Great died in 4 B.C.; our calendar's "year 1" was miscalculated in the 500s A.D.). He grew up in **Nazareth** in Galilee, began His public ministry around age 30 (Luke 3:23), and ministered for about three years. He was crucified under **Pontius Pilate** around **A.D. 30 or 33**, and rose on the third day.
- Draw a simple map of Israel: **Galilee** (north, with the Sea of Galilee, Nazareth, Capernaum, Cana), **Samaria** (middle, where the woman at the well lived), and **Judea** (south, with Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Bethany and Jericho, Zacchaeus's town). The **Jordan River** connects the Sea of Galilee to the Dead Sea (Jesus was baptized there).
- The Gospels were likely written between about A.D. 50 and 95, within the lifetime of eyewitnesses (compare 1 Corinthians 15:3–8, which Paul wrote around A.D. 55 and which includes an even earlier creed).

Connections to Phase 8 (the bridge). Start Week 1 with a quick recap: Malachi promised a messenger → 400 quiet years → Gabriel visits Zechariah (Luke 1) → John the Baptist "prepares the way" (Mark 1:2–4) → Jesus! Point out that the empires from the bridge show up now: Caesar Augustus (Luke 2:1), Herod (Matthew 2), Roman soldiers and Pilate, Pharisees and Sadducees, synagogues, and the Greek language the Gospels were written in.

Key truths to emphasize

- **Jesus is fully God and fully human.** He got tired and wept (John 4:6; 11:35), and He calmed storms and forgave sins (Mark 2:5–12; 4:39).
- **Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament promises.**
- **Jesus loves everyone**, including children, outsiders, sinners and the sick.
- **Jesus died on the cross for our sins** and **rose again on the third day.** This is the center of the gospel (1 Corinthians 15:3–4).
- **We are saved by believing in Jesus** (John 3:16; 20:31), not by being good enough.
- **Jesus calls us to follow Him** and tell others (Matthew 28:19–20).

🙏 Sharing the gospel and responding (important for this phase)

This phase naturally invites kids to trust Jesus. Be ready, warm and **never pressuring**. A simple "ABC" outline:

- **A**dmit: "I have sinned and need God's forgiveness" (Romans 3:23).
- **B**elieve: "Jesus is God's Son, He died for my sins, and He rose again" (John 3:16; Romans 10:9).
- **C**hoose to follow: "I want Jesus to be my Lord and Savior and to follow Him" (John 1:12).

If a child wants to talk or pray, do so in a visible, open space (follow your church's child-safety policy) with another adult nearby. Pray simply together, celebrate, and **tell the parents** (and your pastor/children's director) so they can follow up. Avoid group "raise your hand" pressure with young children; offer individual conversations instead.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
The crucifixion	"Bad men hurt Jesus and He died on a cross. But He let it happen because He loves us, and three days later He came alive again!" Always tell the resurrection in the same breath.	Tell the story plainly (soldiers, the cross, "It is finished"), without graphic description; emphasize love and the resurrection.	Explain why Jesus died (our sins; Isaiah 53:5; Mark 10:45). Discuss Peter's denial and restoration.	Discuss substitutionary atonement, the historical evidence for the crucifixion and resurrection, and why it matters.
Herod killing Bethlehem's baby boys (Matt. 2:16)	Skip. "An angel warned Joseph to take Jesus to Egypt to keep Him safe."	Mention briefly: "Jealous King Herod wanted to hurt baby Jesus."	Briefly mention; Herod's known cruelty fits history.	Discuss evil, suffering and God's protection of His plan (and Jeremiah 31:15 in Matt. 2:18).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Death (Lazarus, Jairus's daughter)	"Jesus is stronger than death!"	Talk honestly; Jesus wept with His friends.	Discuss grief and hope (1 Thess. 4:13).	Discuss resurrection hope and the problem of suffering.
Demons / evil spirits (e.g., Mark 5)	Skip or say "Jesus made a very sick man well."	"Jesus is more powerful than anything evil."	Read Mark 5 with discussion.	Discuss spiritual reality with balance: Jesus has all authority (Col. 2:15).
John the Baptist's death (Mark 6)	Skip.	Skip or "A bad king put John in jail."	Optional, brief.	Optional discussion of faithfulness and cost.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

1. **"Was Jesus a real person?"** Yes! Four Gospels written within one lifetime of Jesus tell about Him, and even non-Christian historians from the first and early second centuries (such as the Jewish historian Josephus and the Roman historian Tacitus) mention Him.
2. **"Is Jesus God or God's Son?"** Both! Christians believe in one God in three persons: the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Jesus is God the Son, who became a human baby (John 1:1, 14).
3. **"Why are there four Gospels instead of one?"** Each writer shows a different side of Jesus, like four photos of the same person from different angles. Having four witnesses also makes the story even more trustworthy (Deuteronomy 19:15).
4. **"Why did Jesus have to die?"** Sin separates us from God and deserves punishment. Jesus, who never sinned, took our punishment in our place so we could be forgiven (Isaiah 53:5; 1 Peter 3:18).
5. **"How did Jesus come back to life?"** God the Father raised Him by His power (Acts 2:24). Many people saw Him alive: the women, the disciples, Thomas, and over 500 people at once (1 Corinthians 15:6).
6. **"Where is Jesus now?"** He went back up to heaven (Luke 24:51; Acts 1:9). He is alive, He hears our prayers, and He promised to come back.
7. **"Did Jesus have brothers and sisters?"** The Gospels mention brothers, including James and Jude, and sisters (Mark 6:3). (Teachers: some Christian traditions understand these as cousins or step-siblings; keep it simple.)
8. **"Can I be Jesus' friend even though I'm a kid?"** Yes! Jesus said, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them" (Mark 10:14).

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Matthew 2:1–12; 5:14–16; 7:24–27; 28:18–20	"Jesus Is the King!" (Matthew)	Jesus is the promised King, and He is with us always.	BibleProject "Overview: Matthew 1-13" & "Matthew 14-28"; Sharefaith Kids "Wise Men"; Bible Journey "Matthew"	Gospel Four Corners	King Jesus Crown
2	Mark 2:1–12; 4:35–41; 10:45	"Jesus the Mighty Servant" (Mark)	Jesus has power over sickness, sin and storms, and He came to serve.	BibleProject "Overview: Mark"; Sharefaith Kids "Jesus Calms the Storm"; Bible Journey "Mark"	Through the Roof Relay	Through-the-Roof House
3	Luke 2:8–20; 19:1–10	"A Savior for Everyone!" (Luke)	Jesus came to seek and save the lost, including me!	BibleProject "Overview: Luke 1-9" & "Luke 10-24"; Sharefaith Kids "Zacchaeus"; Bible Journey "Luke"	Zacchaeus, Come Down!	Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree
4	John 11:25; 19:16–30; 20:1–29; 20:31	"He Is Alive!" (John)	Jesus is God's Son. He died for us and rose again, so believe!	BibleProject "Overview: John 1-12" & "John 13-21"; Sharefaith Kids "Easter / He Is Risen"; Bible Journey "John"	Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt	Rolling-Stone Tomb
5 *(optional)*	Review all 4 Gospels	"Good News Party Sunday"	Four Gospels, one Jesus, and the good news is for you!	Favorite clip review + BibleProject "Gospel of the Kingdom"	Fishers of People Net Tag	Passport Stamp, Badge & Gospel Bracelets

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: "Jesus Is the King!" (Matthew)

Scripture: Matthew 1:21–23; 2:1–12; 5:14–16; 7:24–27; 28:18–20

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that the New Testament begins with Matthew, that Matthew shows Jesus is the promised King (born in Bethlehem, worshiped by the wise men), that Jesus taught people how to live in His kingdom, and that King Jesus promises to be with us always.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Across the Bridge"

- *Supplies:* The floor "bridge" from Phase 8 (painter's tape), a gold paper crown, a flashlight (for the star), a small gift box with three small items (something gold, a small candle or spice for "frankincense," and a small jar for "myrrh").
- *Do:* Have kids walk silently across the bridge one more time: "Shhh... 400 years... Malachi said a messenger and the King would come..." At the far end, turn on the flashlight like a star and set the crown on a chair: "THE KING IS HERE! Welcome to the **New Testament**! The first book is Matthew, and Matthew wants you to know: Jesus is the KING!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Matthew had a job that most people didn't like. He was a tax collector, and many tax collectors cheated people. But one day Jesus walked by Matthew's tax booth and said two words: "Follow me." And Matthew got up, left everything and followed Jesus! Later, Matthew wrote a book to show everyone who Jesus really is: **the King!**
>
> Matthew starts with Jesus' family tree, going all the way back to King David and to Abraham. Jesus was from the royal family, just like God promised!
>
> Then Matthew tells how an angel told Joseph, "Mary will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins." Matthew says this happened to make Isaiah's promise come true: "They will call him Immanuel," which means "God with us."
>
> When Jesus was born in Bethlehem, wise men from far away in the east saw a special star. They traveled a long way to Jerusalem and asked, "Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star and have come to worship him."
>
> King Herod was not happy! He didn't want another king. He asked the priests, "Where will the Messiah be born?" They said, "In Bethlehem! The prophet Micah wrote it."
>
> The star led the wise men right to the house where Jesus was. They bowed down and worshiped Him, and they gave Him treasures: gold, frankincense and myrrh, gifts fit for a king! Then God warned them in a dream not to go back to Herod, so they went home another way.
>
> When Jesus grew up, He taught people about His kingdom. He sat on a mountainside and said, "You are the light of the world... let your light shine before others." He taught them to pray, "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name..." And He said, "Everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock." When the storm came, the house on the rock stood strong!
>
> At the very end of Matthew, after Jesus died and rose again, He gathered His disciples on a mountain and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations... And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."
>
> Jesus is the King. He is God with us. And He is with you, always!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Give each child a turn wearing the crown and saying "Jesus is KING!" Act out the wise men following the flashlight star. Sing "The Wise Man Built His House upon the Rock" (traditional) with motions. Main idea: *Jesus is the King, and He's with me.*
- **Explorers:** Have kids find Matthew 1:1, the first page of the New Testament, and notice how many books come before it (39!). Read the Lord's Prayer together (Matthew 6:9–13).
- **Trailblazers:** Hunt for "fulfilled" verses in Matthew 1–2 (1:22–23 Isaiah; 2:5–6 Micah; 2:15 Hosea; 2:17–18 Jeremiah). Connect each one to the Phase 7 and Phase 8 prophets.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss the Great Commission (28:18–20): what does "make disciples" mean in daily life? Compare Matthew's first and last chapters ("God with us," 1:23, and "I am with you always," 28:20).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the wise men follow? (A star!) (2) What did they give Jesus? (Presents: gold!) (3) Who is the King? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What was Matthew's job before he followed Jesus? (Tax collector.) (2) What does "Immanuel" mean? ("God with us.") (3) What happened to the house built on the rock?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think Matthew began with a family tree? (2) Which Old Testament prophet said Jesus would be born in Bethlehem? (Micah.) (3) What does it mean to be "the light of the world"?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why was King Herod threatened by baby Jesus? Are people still threatened by Jesus' kingship today? (2) What does it look like to build your life "on the rock"? (3) Who is one person you could help "become a disciple"?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Wise Men" (or "Sermon on the Mount" / "Wise and Foolish Builders")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Wise+Men
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Matthew" (or "Birth of Jesus")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Matthew
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Matthew 1-13" and "Overview: Matthew 14-28"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Matthew

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) How does Matthew show that Jesus is the King? (2) What did Jesus teach about how to live in His kingdom?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Gospel Four Corners*, see Games #1.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *King Jesus Crown*, see Activities #1. Coloring Page 1: "The Wise Men Worship the King."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce John 3:16 (all ages) and "For God so loved the world" (Little Lambs). Spell **M-A-T-T-H-E-W** (double T!). Learn the new section shout: "FOUR GOSPELS!"

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, You are the King! Thank You for being "God with us." Help us build our lives on You like a house on the rock. Thank You for being with us always. Amen.

Week 2: "Jesus the Mighty Servant" (Mark)

Scripture: Mark 1:1–3; 2:1–12; 4:35–41; 10:45

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Mark is the shortest, action-packed Gospel, that Jesus has power over sickness, sin and storms, and that Jesus, the mighty one, came to serve and to give His life for us.

Opening hook / object lesson: "On Your Mark!"

- *Supplies:* A stopwatch, a "START" line on the floor, a small blanket or towel (the mat), a spray bottle (storm), a fan (optional).
- *Do:* Line kids up: "On your MARK... get set... GO!" Have them race to the wall and back. "That was fast! Today's book is like that race: it's called **Mark**, and it's the fastest Gospel. Mark keeps saying 'immediately!' Jesus did this, and immediately He did that! Let's see what Jesus did in Mark."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Mark's book starts fast. There's no baby Jesus, no shepherds or wise men. Mark jumps right in: "The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God!" John the Baptist is preaching by the river, Jesus is baptized, and *immediately* Jesus starts teaching, healing and helping people!
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> One day Jesus was teaching in a house in the town of Capernaum. So many people came that the house was packed. People were squished inside and crowded outside the door. Nobody else could get in!
>
> Four friends came carrying a man on a mat. Their friend was paralyzed: he couldn't walk at all. "We have to get him to Jesus!" they said. But they couldn't get through the crowd.
>
> So what did they do? They climbed up onto the flat roof! They dug a big hole right through the roof, *scrape, scrape, scrape*, and they lowered their friend on his mat, right down in front of Jesus!
>
> Jesus saw their faith. He looked at the man and said, "Son, your sins are forgiven."
>
> Some teachers of the law thought, "What? Only God can forgive sins!" Jesus knew what they were thinking. He said, "So that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins..." He turned to the man: "Get up, take your mat and go home." And immediately the man stood

> up, picked up his mat and walked out in front of everyone! The people were amazed and praised God: "We have never seen anything like this!"
>
> Another day, Jesus and His disciples got into a boat to cross the Sea of Galilee. Jesus was tired, so He lay down in the back of the boat on a cushion and fell asleep. Suddenly a furious storm came up! The waves crashed over the boat, and it was filling up with water!
>
> The disciples woke Jesus. "Teacher, don't you care if we drown?"
>
> Jesus got up. He spoke to the wind and the waves: "Quiet! Be still!" And immediately, the wind stopped and everything became completely calm.
>
> The disciples were amazed. "Who is this? Even the wind and the waves obey him!"
>
> Jesus is the mighty Son of God. He can heal, forgive and calm storms. But listen to what Jesus said about why He came: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many." The mightiest person ever came to be a servant and to give His life for us on the cross!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act out the roof story with a towel "mat" and a teddy bear: four kids hold the corners and "lower" the bear onto a table. Then make a "storm" (wiggle, blow, sway) until you say "Quiet! Be still!" and everyone freezes. Main idea: *Jesus is strong and He helps me.*
- **Explorers:** Count how many times Mark 1 says "immediately," "at once" or "just as" (the exact number varies by translation; NIV uses several of these). Discuss: "Who are friends you could bring to Jesus?"
- **Trailblazers:** Read Mark 2:7–12. Why did Jesus forgive sins *before* healing? (He was showing He is God.) Read Mark 1:2–3 and find the Malachi and Isaiah quotes from the last two phases.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Mark 10:42–45: how is greatness in Jesus' kingdom different from the world's idea? Optional: discuss why many Bibles note that Mark 16:9–20 isn't in the earliest manuscripts, and how this is handled honestly by evangelical scholars (no Christian doctrine depends on those verses).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) How did the friends get their friend to Jesus? (Through the roof!) (2) What did Jesus say to the storm? ("Quiet! Be still!") (3) Is Jesus strong? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Jesus say to the paralyzed man first? ("Your sins are forgiven.") (2) What was Jesus doing when the storm started? (Sleeping!) (3) What did the disciples ask after the storm stopped?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why were the teachers of the law upset? (2) What do the friends teach us about bringing others to Jesus? (3) What does it mean that Jesus came "to serve"?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Which storms in your life do you need to trust Jesus with? (2) How does the forgiving-then-healing order show Jesus' identity? (3) What does serving like Jesus look like at school, at home or on a team?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Jesus Calms the Storm" (or "Through the Roof")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jesus+Calms+the+Storm
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Mark" (or "Jesus Heals Paralyzed Man")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Mark
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Mark"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Mark

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did Jesus' miracles show about who He is? (2) How did Jesus show He came to serve?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Through the Roof Relay*, see Games #2 (plus *Quiet! Be Still! Freeze*, Games #4).

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Through-the-Roof House*, see Activities #2. Coloring Page 2: "Through the Roof!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **M-A-R-K**. Say "Matthew, Mark" with motions. Practice John 3:16 in two halves.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, You are mighty! You can calm any storm. Thank You for coming to serve us and to give Your life for us. Help us bring our friends to You. Amen.

Week 3: "A Savior for Everyone!" (Luke)

Scripture: Luke 1:1–4; 2:8–20; 19:1–10

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Doctor Luke carefully wrote the true story of Jesus, that the angels announced Jesus as a Savior for all people, and that Jesus came "to seek and to save the lost," even people like Zacchaeus whom others didn't like.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Lost and Found"

- *Supplies:* A small toy sheep (or a coin) hidden somewhere in the room before class, a toy stethoscope or doctor's bag, a "step stool" or chair.
- *Do:* Put on the stethoscope: "Today's book was written by a doctor! His name is Luke. But first: oh no, I've lost my little sheep! Can you help me find it?" Let kids search. When it's found, celebrate wildly! "That's how Jesus feels about people who are lost from God. Doctor Luke tells us Jesus came to find the lost!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

Luke was a doctor and a careful writer. He said, "I have carefully investigated everything from the beginning," and he talked to people who had seen Jesus with their own eyes. Then he wrote it all down so we could know it's true.

Luke tells us that on the night Jesus was born, some shepherds were out in the fields near Bethlehem, watching their sheep. Shepherds were poor, smelly and often ignored by important people. But God sent His angel to *them* first!

Suddenly an angel appeared, and the glory of the Lord shone all around. The shepherds were terrified! But the angel said, "Do not be afraid. I bring you good news that will cause great joy for **all** the people. Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord." Then a huge army of angels appeared, praising God: "Glory to God in the highest heaven, and on earth peace!"

The shepherds hurried to Bethlehem and found Mary, Joseph and baby Jesus, lying in a manger, just as the angel said. They told everyone what they had seen!

Years later, when Jesus was grown up, He walked through the city of Jericho. A huge crowd was there. In that city lived a man named **Zacchaeus**. He was a chief tax collector, and he was very rich, because he had cheated people. Nobody liked Zacchaeus.

Zacchaeus wanted to see Jesus, but he had a problem: he was short! He couldn't see over the crowd. So he ran ahead and climbed up into a sycamore-fig tree.

When Jesus came to that spot, He stopped, looked up into the tree and said, "Zacchaeus, come down immediately. I must stay at your house today."

Zacchaeus scrambled down and welcomed Jesus with joy! But the people grumbled, "Jesus is going to be the guest of a sinner!"

But Zacchaeus's heart had changed. He stood up and said, "Look, Lord! Here and now I give half of my possessions to the poor, and if I have cheated anybody out of anything, I will pay back four times the amount."

Jesus smiled and said, "Today salvation has come to this house... For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Shepherds or rich men, little kids or grown-ups, people everyone likes or people nobody likes: Jesus came to be the Savior for everyone. That includes you!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Have kids "climb a tree" (stand on tiptoes, reach up), then call each child by name: "____, come down! I want to be your friend!" Main idea: *Jesus knows my name and loves me.*
- **Explorers:** Sing the traditional "Zacchaeus Was a Wee Little Man" song with motions. Find Luke 2:11 and Luke 19:10 in the Bible.

- **Trailblazers:** Read Luke 1:1–4 and discuss what makes Luke a careful historian. Compare Luke 15 (lost sheep, coin, son) with the Zacchaeus story: what's the common theme?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Zacchaeus's repentance: what does real change look like (making things right, generosity)? Discuss who the "Zacchaeuses" are in your school, the people others avoid.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who did the angels visit? (Shepherds!) (2) Where did Zacchaeus climb? (A tree!) (3) Does Jesus love everyone? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What was Luke's job? (Doctor.) (2) What did the angel say the good news was? (3) What did Zacchaeus promise to do after he met Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think God told shepherds first? (2) Why did people grumble about Jesus visiting Zacchaeus? (3) What does Luke 19:10 tell us about why Jesus came?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) How does Luke show special care for the poor and outsiders? (2) What does real repentance look like in Zacchaeus? (3) How can you "seek the lost" the way Jesus did?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Zacchaeus" (or "Shepherds and Angels")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Zacchaeus
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Luke" (or "Zacchaeus")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Luke
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Luke 1-9" and "Overview: Luke 10-24"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Luke

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) Who did Jesus reach out to that others ignored? (2) What changed in Zacchaeus after he met Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Zacchaeus, Come Down!*, see Games #3.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree*, see Activities #3. Coloring Page 3: "Zacchaeus in the Tree."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **L-U-K-E** (silent E). Say "Matthew, Mark, Luke" with motions. Say John 3:16 all the way through.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, thank You for coming to find the lost. Thank You that You know our names and love everyone. Help us to be kind to people others leave out. Amen.

Week 4: "He Is Alive!" (John)

Scripture: John 3:16; 11:25; 19:16–30; 20:1–29; 20:31

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that John shows Jesus is God's Son, that Jesus died on the cross for our sins ("It is finished!") and rose again on the third day, and that John wrote so that we would **believe** and have life in Jesus' name.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Empty Box"

- *Supplies:* A box or plastic egg decorated like a tomb with a "stone" lid, empty inside except for a folded strip of white cloth; a small cross; a flashlight.
- *Do:* "This box is like a tomb, a place where people were buried. What do you think is inside?" Let kids guess. Slowly open it: only a folded cloth! "It's EMPTY! Today we find out why the most important tomb in history is empty!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> John was one of Jesus' closest friends. He was a fisherman who left his nets to follow Jesus. He called himself "the disciple whom Jesus loved." Many years later, John wrote down what he had seen so that we would believe that Jesus is God's Son.
>
> John saw Jesus do amazing signs: turn water into wine, feed 5,000 people with one boy's lunch, walk on water, and open the eyes of a man born blind. John heard Jesus say, "I am the light of the world," "I am the good shepherd," and "I am the way and the truth and the life."
>
> Once, Jesus' friend Lazarus died. When Jesus arrived, Lazarus had been in the tomb for four days. Jesus told Lazarus's sister Martha, "I am the resurrection and the life." Jesus cried with His friends. Then He called out in a loud voice, "Lazarus, come out!" And Lazarus walked out of the tomb, alive!
>
> But some leaders hated Jesus. They had Him arrested. Roman soldiers made fun of Him and put a crown of thorns on His head. Then they nailed Him to a wooden cross. John was there, standing near the cross with Jesus' mother, Mary. Even while He was suffering, Jesus cared for His mom and asked John to take care of her.
>
> Then Jesus said, "It is finished." He bowed His head and died. Jesus had finished the job He came to do: paying for our sins, taking the punishment we deserved, because He loves us. His friends gently laid His body in a tomb, a cave in a garden, and a big stone was rolled in front.
>
> Everyone was so sad. But that's not the end of the story!
>
> Early on Sunday morning, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb. The stone had been rolled away! She ran to tell Peter and John. They ran to the tomb. John ran faster and got there first! Inside, they saw the strips of linen cloth lying there, and the cloth that had been around Jesus' head folded up by itself. The tomb was **empty**!
>
> Mary stayed outside, crying. Then she turned around and saw a man. She thought he was the gardener. Then He said her name: "Mary." She knew that voice. It was **Jesus! He was ALIVE!**

> Later Jesus appeared to His disciples. But Thomas wasn't there, and he said, "Unless I see the nail marks in his hands... I will not believe." A week later, Jesus came again and said, "Thomas, put your finger here; see my hands... Stop doubting and believe." Thomas fell down and said, "My Lord and my God!"
>
> John wrote: "These are written that you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." Because "God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." **Jesus is alive!**

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use the box: "Jesus died... (close box) ...but on Sunday... (open box) ...He's ALIVE!" Repeat several times, and have kids shout "He's ALIVE!" Main idea: *Jesus loves me so much He died for me, and He's alive!*
- **Explorers:** List the 7 "I AM" sayings on the board and let kids draw a symbol for each. Practice John 3:16 with motions (heart, world/circle, "gave" with open hands, "believe" pointing to the head and heart, "eternal life" hands circling forever).
- **Trailblazers:** Read John 20:30–31 and discuss John's purpose. Read the Thomas story: is it okay to have questions? How did Jesus respond to Thomas's doubt (with evidence and invitation, not anger)?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss evidence for the resurrection: the empty tomb, the many eyewitnesses (1 Cor. 15:3–8), women as the first witnesses (unlikely to be invented in that culture), and the transformed disciples who were willing to suffer. Ambassadors can lead a younger group in the "Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt."

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Where did Jesus die? (On a cross.) (2) What did Mary find at the tomb? (It was empty!) (3) Is Jesus alive today? (YES!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Jesus say before Lazarus came out? ("I am the resurrection and the life.") (2) What did Jesus mean by "It is finished"? (3) What did Thomas say when he saw Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did Jesus have to die? (2) Who were the first people to see the empty tomb and the risen Jesus? (3) Why did John write his book (John 20:31)?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Which evidence for the resurrection do you find strongest? (2) How would you explain John 3:16 to a friend who's never been to church? (3) What difference does the resurrection make for how you face death, fear or failure?

📺 Video for the week:

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Easter" / "He Is Risen" (or "Lazarus")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Easter
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"John" (or "Resurrection")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Resurrection

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: John 1-12" and "Overview: John 13-21"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+John

Preview every video before class, especially crucifixion scenes, for Little Lambs. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the video show about why Jesus died? (2) How did Jesus' friends react when they saw He was alive?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt*, see Games #5.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Rolling-Stone Tomb*, see Activities #4. Coloring Page 4: "He Is Risen!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **J-O-H-N** (silent H). Say all 4 Gospels, then all 43 books! Begin oral check-offs.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, thank You for loving us so much that You died on the cross for our sins. Thank You that You are ALIVE! Help us believe in You and follow You forever. Amen.

(Teacher: After the prayer, gently let kids know that anyone who has questions about following Jesus can talk with you or their parents. See "Sharing the gospel and responding" above.)

Week 5 (optional): "Good News Party Sunday"

Use the End-of-Phase Review & Celebration plan below. Play *Fishers of People Net Tag* (Games #6), make Gospel Bracelets (Activities #5), finish oral check-offs, stamp Bible Passports, and award the ✝️ "I Met Jesus!" badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Library Song": the Old Testament plus the Gospels!

Verses 1–4 use **"Ten Little Fingers,"** Verse 5 uses **"Yankee Doodle,"** and the NEW Verse 6 uses **"Frère Jacques" ("Are You Sleeping?")**. Before Verse 6, everyone whispers the **Bridge**: "Shhh... 400 years..." and then shouts "JESUS IS HERE!" All lyrics are written out below; sing them every week.

Verse 1: LAW (5) *(tune: Ten Little Fingers)*

> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, the books of the Law! Genesis, Exodus,

> Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, FIVE!

Verse 2: HISTORY (12)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, then First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther: History! Twelve books of HIS-TO-RY!

Verse 3: POETRY / WISDOM (5)

> Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, they're Poetry and Wisdom! Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, that's FIVE!

Verse 4: MAJOR PROPHETS (5)

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

Verse 5: MINOR PROPHETS (12) *(tune: Yankee Doodle)*

> Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah, Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai! Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets! Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!

🌉 **The Bridge (spoken)**

> *(whisper)* Shhh... four hundred years... God was getting ready... *(shout)* JESUS IS HERE!

Verse 6: THE GOSPELS (4), NEW! *(tune: Frère Jacques; each line is sung twice)*

> **Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,** *(Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,)* **Then comes John!** *(Then comes John!)* **Tell-ing us of Je-sus,** *(Tell-ing us of Je-sus,)* **Good News: FOUR!** *(Good News: FOUR!)*

Tag (shout it!)

> Thirty-nine and FOUR makes... FORTY-THREE! JESUS DIED AND ROSE FOR ME!

Bonus round (sing it as a round!): Because "Frère Jacques" is a round, split the class into 2–4 groups and sing Verse 6 as a round. Group 2 starts when Group 1 reaches "Then comes John!" It sounds amazing, and it drills the four names over and over.

Hand motions for the 4 new books

Book	Motion
Matthew	Kneel on one knee and bow your head like the wise men: "King!"
Mark	Run in place, pumping your arms: "Immediately!"
Luke	Open your arms wide: "For everyone!"
John	Draw a big circle in the air (the world), then cross your arms over your heart: "God so loved the world!"

Review motions for books learned earlier (1–39). These match the motions used in earlier phases and the Books of the Bible Memory System:

Section	Book → motion
Law	Genesis: palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up (sunrise) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart
History	Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: hold up 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear (listening) · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then crown on head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands at mouth
Poetry / Wisdom	Job: hands open up, then fold over heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head with one finger · Ecclesiastes: blow a puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands
Major Prophets	Isaiah: two fingers to lips, then hand up ("Send me!") · Jeremiah: shape clay in a circle · Lamentations: tears down cheeks, then arms up like a sunrise · Ezekiel: go floppy, then stand tall · Daniel: lion jaws snap shut
Minor Prophets	Hosea: arms out, pull back in ("Come home!") · Joel: locust fingers · Amos: drop a plumb line · Obadiah: one finger · Jonah: fish-mouth gulp · Micah: tiny roof · Nahum: fist tower tumbles · Habakkuk: hand over eyes (watchtower) · Zephaniah: song floats from heart · Haggai: hammer, then roof over head · Zechariah: donkey ride · Malachi: hand at mouth, point ahead

📣 Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What does Gospel mean?" **Kids:** "GOOD NEWS!" **Teacher:** "How many Gospels?" **Kids:** "FOUR GOSPELS, ONE JESUS!" **Teacher:** "Name them!" **Kids (with motions):** "MATTHEW, MARK, LUKE AND JOHN!" **Teacher:** "Where is Jesus now?" **Kids:** "HE'S ALIVE!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Testament Toss:** Toss a soft ball to a child and call "Old" or "New." The child names any book from that Testament. (So far, the only New Testament books are the 4 Gospels!)
2. **Section Stand-Up:** Law → History → Poetry/Wisdom → Major → Minor → Gospels. Each group stands and says its books.
3. **Before & After across the bridge:** "What's the last book of the Old Testament?" (Malachi) "What's the first book of the New Testament?" (Matthew) "What's after Luke?" (John)
4. **Gospel Stories Match:** Teacher says a story; kids shout and do the motion of the Gospel it's (most famously) from: "Zacchaeus!" (Luke) "Wise men!" (Matthew) "Thomas sees Jesus!" (John) "Friends through the roof!" (Mark, also in Matthew and Luke!)
5. **43-Book Marathon (Trailblazers+):** Say all 43 books in order. Time it.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on "Matthew, Mark, Luke and John," the motions, and "Gospel means Good News." The Frère Jacques verse is very easy for them!
- **Explorers:** Goal: say and spell all four Gospels; sing all six verses.
- **Trailblazers:** Goal: say all 43 books in order without the song; give each Gospel's "one word" and one key story.
- **Ambassadors:** Goal: say all 43 books; lead the round; explain why there are four Gospels.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & first sounds)

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Matthew	**M**	"m-m-m"	👑 crown
Mark	**M**	"m-m-m"	🏃 runner
Luke	**L**	"l-l-l"	🤗 open arms
John	**J**	"j-j-j"	❤️ heart
Jesus	**J**	"j-j-j"	✝️ cross

Bonus: "Two M's, then L, then J!" (M-M-L-J). Clap it: "M! M! L! J!"

Explorers (book names)

1. Matthew
2. Mark
3. Luke
4. John

5. Gospel
6. Jesus
7. *Review:* Malachi, Micah, Isaiah, Genesis, Psalms

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocabulary words)

- Book names: Matthew, Mark, Luke, John
- Vocab: **gospel**, **disciple**, **miracle**, **parable**, **resurrection**

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocabulary with definitions)

Word	Definition
Gospel	"Good news": the message that Jesus died for our sins and rose again; also the name for the four books about His life.
Disciple	A follower and learner who lives the way the teacher lives.
Parable	A short story Jesus told, using everyday things to teach a spiritual truth (e.g., the Lost Son).
Synoptic	"Seeing together": Matthew, Mark and Luke, which share many of the same stories.
Incarnation	God the Son becoming a human being ("The Word became flesh," John 1:14).
Atonement	Jesus' death making us "at one" with God by paying for our sin.
Resurrection	Rising from the dead to a new, never-dying body, as Jesus did on the third day.
Messiah / Christ	"Anointed One," the promised King. "Christ" is the Greek word, not Jesus' last name!
Repentance	Turning away from sin and toward God (like Zacchaeus).

👏 Syllable-clap method

Book	Claps	Spell in rhythm
Mat-thew	2	M-A-T · T-H-E-W
Mark	1	M-A-R-K
Luke	1	L-U-K-E
John	1	J-O-H-N
Gos-pel	2	G-O-S · P-E-L
Je-sus	2	J-E · S-U-S

Tricky-spot alerts: Ma**TT**hew (double T, and "TH" sounds like "T" here, not like "the"), Luk**E** (silent E), Jo**H**n (silent H).

🏃 "Spell It Out" relay

1. Teams line up. At the far end, each team has a basket of letter cards for M-A-T-T-H-E-W, M-A-R-K, L-U-K-E and J-O-H-N, all mixed together.

2. Call "MATTHEW!" One runner at a time brings back a letter in order.
3. When a team finishes a word, they do its motion and shout its "one word" ("MATTHEW: KING!").
4. Then call the next Gospel, using the same basket (so kids must hunt for the right letters).
5. *Little Lambs:* Grab the first letter and run back shouting the name. *Ambassadors:* Spell all four Gospels and "RESURRECTION" in one run.

🐝 Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Matthew	**Matthew** shows that Jesus is the King.
Mark	**Mark** is the shortest Gospel.
Luke	Doctor **Luke** wrote about Zacchaeus.
John	**John** wrote, "For God so loved the world."
Gospel	**Gospel** means "good news."
Jesus	**Jesus** died and rose again.
disciple	Peter was a **disciple** of Jesus.
miracle	Calming the storm was a **miracle**.
shepherds	The angels told the **shepherds** about Jesus.
Zacchaeus	**Zacchaeus** climbed a tree to see Jesus.
resurrection (Ambassadors)	The **resurrection** happened on the third day.
Bethlehem	Jesus was born in **Bethlehem**.

📖 Read-aloud practice passage

> The New Testament starts with four **Gospels**. Gospel means **good news**! **Matthew** shows Jesus is the **King**. Wise men brought Him gifts. **Mark** shows Jesus is a mighty **Servant**. He calmed a **storm** and healed a man who came through the **roof**. **Luke** shows Jesus is the **Savior** for everyone. He called **Zacchaeus** down from a tree. **John** shows Jesus is God's **Son**. Jesus died on the **cross** for our sins, and on the third day He rose again. The tomb was **empty**! "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son."

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What does the word "Gospel" mean?
2. Name the four Gospels.
3. True or False: Jesus was born in Bethlehem.

4. What did the wise men follow to find Jesus?
5. Who climbed a tree to see Jesus?
6. What did Jesus say to the storm? ("Quiet! Be _____!")
7. Fill in the blank: "For God so _____ the world." (John 3:16)
8. Who did the angels visit on the night Jesus was born?
9. True or False: The tomb was empty on Sunday morning because Jesus rose from the dead.
10. How did the four friends get the man to Jesus?
11. What is the first book of the New Testament?
12. Was Jesus asleep or awake when the storm began?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who said, "Zacchaeus, come down immediately"? (Who said it?)
14. Which Gospel was written by a doctor? (Which book?)
15. What was Matthew's job before he followed Jesus?
16. What three gifts did the wise men bring?
17. Fill in the blank: "You are the _____ of the world." (Matthew 5:14)
18. Which Gospel is the shortest?
19. Who said, "My Lord and my God!"? (Who said it?)
20. What did Jesus say right before He died on the cross in John's Gospel?
21. True or False: Zacchaeus promised to pay back four times what he had cheated.
22. Which friend of Jesus did He raise after four days in the tomb?
23. Who was the first person to see the risen Jesus in John 20?
24. Which Gospel ends with "Go and make disciples of all nations"? (Which book?)

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said, "Surely this man was the Son of God!" at the cross in Mark? (Who said it?)
26. Fill in the blank: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to _____." (Mark 10:45)
27. Which three Gospels are called the "Synoptic" Gospels?
28. Name three of Jesus' seven "I AM" sayings in John.
29. To whom did Luke address his Gospel?
30. Which Old Testament prophet is quoted at the very start of Mark, along with Isaiah?
31. What other New Testament book did Luke write?
32. What is the purpose of John's Gospel, according to John 20:31?
33. Fill in the blank: Luke 19:10: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the _____."
34. What does "Immanuel" mean, and which Gospel uses it in chapter 1?
35. True or False: Matthew's family tree of Jesus starts with Abraham.
36. Which Roman governor sentenced Jesus to be crucified?
37. What was the first sign (miracle) Jesus did in John's Gospel?
38. Which Gospel tells the parables of the Lost Sheep, the Lost Coin and the Lost Son?

🔑 Answer Key

1. Good news
2. Matthew, Mark, Luke, John

3. True (Matthew 2:1; Luke 2:4–7)
4. A star
5. Zacchaeus (Luke 19:4)
6. still (Mark 4:39)
7. loved
8. Shepherds (Luke 2:8–14)
9. True
10. They lowered him through a hole in the roof (Mark 2:4).
11. Matthew
12. Asleep (Mark 4:38)
13. Jesus (Luke 19:5)
14. Luke (Colossians 4:14)
15. Tax collector (Matthew 9:9)
16. Gold, frankincense and myrrh (Matthew 2:11)
17. light
18. Mark
19. Thomas (John 20:28)
20. "It is finished." (John 19:30)
21. True (Luke 19:8)
22. Lazarus (John 11)
23. Mary Magdalene (John 20:14–18)
24. Matthew (28:19)
25. The Roman centurion (Mark 15:39)
26. serve (and to give his life as a ransom for many)
27. Matthew, Mark and Luke
28. Any three: bread of life (6:35), light of the world (8:12), the gate (10:7, 9), the good shepherd (10:11), the resurrection and the life (11:25), the way and the truth and the life (14:6), the true vine (15:1)
29. Theophilus (Luke 1:3)
30. Malachi (Malachi 3:1 in Mark 1:2; Isaiah 40:3 in Mark 1:3)
31. Acts (Acts 1:1)
32. "That you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."
33. lost
34. "God with us," in Matthew 1:23
35. True (Matthew 1:1–2; Luke's family tree goes back to Adam, Luke 3:38)
36. Pontius Pilate
37. Turning water into wine at a wedding in Cana (John 2:1–11)
38. Luke (chapter 15)

Games

🎮 Game #1: Gospel Four Corners

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Four signs for the four corners of the room: MATTHEW 👑, MARK 🏃, LUKE 🤗, JOHN ❤️
- **Setup:** One child (or the teacher) is "It" and stands in the middle with eyes closed.
- **How to play:** "It" counts down from 10 while everyone runs to a corner, doing that corner's motion. At "0," "It" (eyes still closed) calls out a Gospel. Everyone in that corner must answer a question together ("Name a story from this Gospel!" or "Spell your Gospel!"). If they answer correctly, they stay in; if not, they sit out one round (or join "It" as helpers).
- **How to win:** Last players standing win. Or, for no-elimination, every correct answer earns that corner a point.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* No one sits out; they just shout the corner's name and do the motion. *Older:* Questions require a specific story unique to that Gospel ("Name a story ONLY in Luke").
- **Learning goal:** The four Gospel names, their symbols and key stories.

🎮 Game #2: Through the Roof Relay

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with a stuffed animal)
- **Supplies:** One beach towel or small blanket per team (the mat), one stuffed animal per team (the paralyzed man), cones; optional: a table to represent the "roof"
- **Setup:** Teams of 4 (the four friends!). A finish line at the far end represents Jesus.
- **How to play:** Each team carries its "friend" on the towel (each kid holding a corner) to the far end without dropping it. At the "roof" (a table or a hula hoop on the floor), they must gently "lower" the friend down and say together, "Jesus, help our friend!" Then the friend "gets up and walks" (one teammate grabs the stuffed animal and runs it back). Then the next group of four goes.
- **How to win:** First team to have all members carry the mat wins, or the team with the fewest "drops."
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teacher holds one corner; walk, no running. *Older:* Add a trivia question at the roof; a wrong answer means you must "dig through the roof" (10 jumping jacks) first.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork in bringing friends to Jesus (Mark 2); Jesus' power to forgive and heal.

🎮 Game #3: Zacchaeus, Come Down!

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** Chairs, low benches or carpet squares ("trees"), one fewer than the number of players (like musical chairs); music
- **Setup:** Arrange the "trees" in a circle.
- **How to play:** While the music plays, kids walk around the trees. When the music stops, everyone "climbs a tree" (stands on/at a carpet square). The child without a tree becomes "Jesus." They walk up to any tree, point and say, "_____, come down! I want to come to your house today!" That child comes down, and the two link arms and help call the next round. *No one is out*: the "found" kids join Jesus' crowd, cheering. Remove a tree each round.

- **How to win:** Everyone wins when everyone has been "found"! Celebrate: "The Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost!"
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teacher plays Jesus each round. *Older (Trailblazers):* Whoever is called down must answer a trivia question to join the crowd.
- **Learning goal:** Jesus seeks and saves the lost (Luke 19:10) and knows each of us by name.

🎮 Game #4: "Quiet! Be Still!" Storm Freeze

- **Best for:** All ages (great energy burner)
- **Supplies:** A blue sheet or parachute (optional), music or a rain stick
- **Setup:** Kids spread out (or hold the parachute edges).
- **How to play:** The teacher calls out storm actions: "Wind is blowing!" (sway), "Waves are crashing!" (jump), "Rain is pouring!" (wiggle fingers down), "Boat is rocking!" (rock side to side). Then, at a random moment, the teacher (as Jesus) stands up and says, "QUIET! BE STILL!" Everyone must freeze immediately and silently. Anyone who moves or giggles must answer a question ("Which Gospel are we learning?" "Spell MARK!") to rejoin.
- **How to win:** Players who freeze perfectly earn a point; the most points at the end wins (or everyone wins a "calm sea" sticker).
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use the parachute and no questions. *Older:* Let an Ambassador be "Jesus"; add longer "freeze" times.
- **Learning goal:** Jesus' power over nature (Mark 4:35–41).

🎮 Game #5: Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt

- **Best for:** All ages (Ambassadors lead teams of younger kids)
- **Supplies:** 12 plastic eggs (or small boxes), each with a small item and a Scripture slip; one empty egg (the 12th); a "tomb" (cardboard box with a round "stone")
- **Setup:** Hide the eggs around the room or building. Suggested contents (in order):
    1. Tiny crown: Matthew 2:2 (wise men worship the King)
    2. Small cloth or bandage: Mark 2:11 (the man on the mat walks)
    3. Seashell or blue paper: Mark 4:39 ("Quiet! Be still!")
    4. Leaf: Luke 19:4–5 (Zacchaeus)
    5. Bread piece (cracker): John 6:35 ("I am the bread of life")
    6. Palm leaf (green paper): John 12:13 ("Hosanna!")
    7. Cup: Luke 22:20 ("the new covenant in my blood")
    8. Three coins or silver paper: Matthew 26:15 (thirty silver coins)
    9. Small cross: John 19:30 ("It is finished")
    10. Cloth strip: John 19:40 (linen strips)
    11. Small stone: John 20:1 (stone rolled away)
    12. **EMPTY!**: Matthew 28:6 ("He is not here; he has risen, just as he said.")
- **How to play:** Teams search for eggs (each team finds one color, or teams find all and then share). Then everyone sits in a circle and opens the eggs in order (numbered), reading the verse and retelling the story together. The empty egg is opened last, and everyone shouts "HE IS RISEN!"
- **How to win:** Every team that finds its eggs wins; the true "prize" is the empty egg!

- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Hide in easy places; teacher reads verses. *Older:* Give riddle clues to each hiding place; teams must find the verse in their own Bibles.
- **Learning goal:** The story of Jesus' life, death and resurrection in order.

🎮 Game #6: Fishers of People Net Tag

- **Best for:** All ages (review Sunday)
- **Supplies:** Open space; cones for boundaries
- **Setup:** Start with two "fishermen" (Peter and Andrew!) holding hands to form a "net."
- **How to play:** Jesus said, "Come, follow me, and I will send you out to fish for people" (Mark 1:17). The fishermen chase the "fish." When they tag someone, that person joins the net by holding hands. The net keeps growing! Only the kids at the ends of the net can tag. When the net reaches 6, it can split into two nets of 3. Before joining the net, a caught fish must say one Gospel name (or the memory verse) to get "on board."
- **How to win:** The last fish caught becomes the first fisherman next round.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Walk, don't run; teacher is part of the net. *Older:* Caught fish must say all 43 books before joining (or a section of them).
- **Learning goal:** Jesus calls us to follow Him and bring others; review of the Gospels.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-09-printables.html`.

Page 1: "The Wise Men Worship the King" (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A simple house in Bethlehem with a large shining star above it. Inside the doorway, Mary holds toddler Jesus on her lap. Three wise men in rich robes kneel before Him, holding out a treasure chest (gold), an incense jar (frankincense) and a small bottle (myrrh). Camels rest outside.
- **Caption:** "They bowed down and worshiped him." (Matthew 2:11)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What gift would you give King Jesus?" "Why did the wise men travel so far?" "How can we worship Jesus today?"

Page 2: "Through the Roof!" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A cut-away view of a crowded house with a flat roof. On the roof, four friends hold ropes and lower a man on a mat through a big hole. Below, Jesus reaches up with a smile while the crowd looks up in surprise. Bits of roof are falling. (Optional second panel: the man walking out carrying his mat, with his arms raised.)
- **Caption:** "Get up, take your mat and go home." (Mark 2:11)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Which friend would you be?" "Who could you bring to Jesus?" "What did Jesus forgive first?"

Page 3: "Zacchaeus in the Tree" (Week 3)

- **Scene:** A big sycamore-fig tree with wide branches. A short man (Zacchaeus) peeks out from the leaves. Below, Jesus looks up and points, with a smile; a crowd behind Him shows surprised faces. Add a little sheep near Jesus' feet for "the lost."
- **Caption:** "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." (Luke 19:10)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "How do you think Zacchaeus felt when Jesus said his name?" "Who is someone others leave out that you could include?"

Page 4: "He Is Risen!" (Week 4)

- **Scene:** A garden at sunrise. A tomb carved in rock with a big round stone rolled to the side; inside, folded linen cloths. Outside, Mary Magdalene turns in joyful surprise toward Jesus, who stands in bright light with His arms open (nail marks gently visible). Flowers bloom everywhere. Three empty crosses stand on a distant hill.
- **Caption:** "He is not here; he has risen!" (Matthew 28:6) / "I am the resurrection and the life." (John 11:25)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What colors show happiness?" "What did Mary feel when she heard Jesus say her name?" "Why is the empty tomb the best news ever?"

Page 5: "Jesus Calms the Storm" (bonus)

- **Scene:** A small fishing boat on huge waves; dark clouds on one side and clear sky breaking through on the other. Jesus stands at the front of the boat with one hand raised. The disciples hold on in shock.
- **Caption:** "Even the wind and the waves obey him!" (Mark 4:41)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What 'storms' (scary things) do you face?" "How can you pray when you're scared?"

Page 6: "Four Gospels, One Jesus" book-name page

- **Scene:** A big cross in the center with a sunrise behind it. In the four corners, four open books labeled MATTHEW (with a crown), MARK (with running sandals), LUKE (with open arms / a little sheep) and JOHN (with a heart). A banner across the top: "GOSPEL = GOOD NEWS!" Banner across the bottom: "43 of 66 books!"
- **Caption:** "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son." (John 3:16)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** Say each Gospel as you color it. "Which Gospel story is your favorite?"

Activities & Crafts

👑 Activity #1: King Jesus Crown (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Gold or yellow cardstock strips (crown-shaped, pre-cut points), plastic "jewels" or stickers, glue, markers, stapler.

- **Steps:**
    1. Write "JESUS IS KING!" across the front of the crown.
    2. Decorate with jewels and stars (for the wise men's star).
    3. On the inside write "Matthew 2:2" or "Immanuel = God with us."
    4. Size to the child's head and staple.
    5. **Twist:** Explain we are not the kings; Jesus is. Kids can wear it, then take it off and "lay it down" before a cross to show "Jesus is King of my life."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-written crowns; stickers only. *Explorers:* Write the four Gospels on four points. *Trailblazers:* Write four Old Testament prophecies Jesus fulfilled on the points. *Ambassadors:* Write Matthew 28:18–20 inside and lead the "lay it down" moment.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus is the promised King (Matthew).

🏠 Activity #2: Through-the-Roof House (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Small boxes (tissue or cereal box cut down) or folded cardstock "houses," a square hole cut in the top, yarn, a craft stick or clothespin person, a small fabric or paper "mat," tape, markers.
- **Steps:**
    1. Decorate the box as a house; draw Jesus and people inside (on the inner back wall).
    2. Tape the craft-stick man to a paper mat.
    3. Tie yarn to each corner of the mat (or two strings).
    4. Lower the man through the roof hole into the house, and pull him back out "walking"!
    5. Write "Mark 2:11, Get up and walk!" on the side.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-made house; they color and lower the man. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Add four friend figures on the roof with names of friends they're praying for. *Ambassadors:* Help younger kids and explain the forgive-then-heal point.
- **What it teaches:** Bringing friends to Jesus; Jesus' power and forgiveness.

🌳 Activity #3: Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper cups (one per child), green tissue or construction paper, a craft stick per child, a small paper Zacchaeus figure, tape, scissors, markers.
- **Steps:**
    1. Turn the cup upside down and poke a slit in the bottom (teacher).
    2. Color the cup brown like a tree trunk; glue green paper "leaves" around the top edge.
    3. Tape Zacchaeus to the top of a craft stick.
    4. Push the stick up through the slit from inside the cup, so Zacchaeus can "climb up" and "come down" as you push and pull the stick.
    5. Write "Luke 19:10" on the trunk.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut and pre-slit. *Explorers:* Full craft; retell the story to a partner. *Trailblazers:* Write on the leaves the four ways Zacchaeus changed. *Ambassadors:* Write names of "lost" friends they'll pray for on the leaves (privately).
- **What it teaches:** Jesus seeks and saves the lost; real life change.

🪨 Activity #4: Rolling-Stone Tomb (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Paper plates (one and a half per child), gray paint or crayons, a paper fastener (brad), a strip of white cloth or paper, markers, a small cross sticker.
- **Steps:**
    1. Cut a paper plate in half; staple or glue the half-plate onto a whole plate to make a "pocket" tomb, with an opening (door) drawn on it.
    2. Color the tomb gray and the background as a garden sunrise.
    3. Cut a gray circle ("stone") and attach it with a brad so it can roll aside to reveal the doorway.
    4. Behind the door, glue a folded white cloth strip and write "HE IS RISEN!"
    5. Write John 11:25 around the edge.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-assembled; they color and roll the stone. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Write John 3:16 on the back. *Ambassadors:* Write out the ABC gospel outline on the back to use when sharing with a friend.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus died and rose again; the empty tomb.

📿 Activity #5: Gospel Bracelet (review / Week 5)

- **Supplies:** Elastic cord or yarn; pony beads in gold, dark gray, red, white and green.
- **Steps (string the beads and say what each means):**
    1. **Gold:** God loves you and made you to know Him (John 3:16).
    2. **Dark gray:** Sin, the wrong things we do, separates us from God (Romans 3:23).
    3. **Red:** Jesus died on the cross to pay for our sin (John 19:30).
    4. **White:** When we trust Jesus, He forgives us and makes us clean (1 John 1:9). And He rose again!
    5. **Green:** We grow by following Jesus, reading the Bible and praying (2 Peter 3:18).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Larger beads and pipe cleaners; teacher says the meaning. *Explorers:* Make two, one to keep and one to give away. *Trailblazers:* Memorize a verse for each bead. *Ambassadors:* Use the bracelet to explain the gospel to a younger child.
- **What it teaches:** The gospel message in a simple, memorable, shareable way.

💡 Activity #6: "I AM" Lightbulb Chart (Trailblazers & Ambassadors) / "I AM" Picture Cards (younger)

- **Supplies:** Poster board, seven lightbulb (or lamp) shapes, markers, Bibles.
- **Steps:**
    1. Look up each "I AM" saying in John (6:35; 8:12; 10:9; 10:11; 11:25; 14:6; 15:5).
    2. Write the reference and saying on each lightbulb, plus a picture (bread, light, gate, shepherd, empty tomb, road, vine).
    3. Add a line: "What this means for me..."
    4. Hang the chart in the classroom for the rest of the year.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs/Explorers:* Color 7 picture cards and play a matching game ("Jesus said, 'I am the... ' [show bread] ...BREAD of life!"). *Ambassadors:* Connect "I AM" to God's name in Exodus 3:14 (and John 8:58).
- **What it teaches:** Who Jesus is, in His own words.

Word Puzzles

🔀 Word Scramble

Unscramble these words from Phase 9.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	WEHTTAM	Shows Jesus is King
2	KRAM	Shortest Gospel
3	EKUL	Written by a doctor
4	NHOJ	"God so loved the world"
5	SPLEOG	Means "good news"
6	SUSEJ	God's Son
7	CEUAZSHAC	Climbed a tree
8	DREHSPHES	Heard the angels first
9	MOTB	It was empty!
10	MORST	Jesus calmed it
11	SORCS	Jesus died on it for us
12	VELIEBE	John wrote so we would ___
13	RUSLAZA	Came out of the tomb alive

Answer key: 1. MATTHEW 2. MARK 3. LUKE 4. JOHN 5. GOSPEL 6. JESUS 7. ZACCHAEUS 8. SHEPHERDS 9. TOMB 10. STORM 11. CROSS 12. BELIEVE 13. LAZARUS

✏️ Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: Luke, roof, King, John, alive, shepherds, Mark, tree, Matthew, Gospel, star, storm, cross

> The word _____ means good news. _____ shows that Jesus is the _____. Wise men followed a _____ to worship Him. _____ shows Jesus in action. Four friends lowered a man through a _____, and Jesus calmed a _____ on the sea. Doctor _____ tells how angels visited _____ and how Zacchaeus climbed a _____. _____ tells us that Jesus died on the _____ for our sins, but on the third day He was _____ again!

Answer key: Gospel, Matthew, King, star, Mark, roof, storm, Luke, shepherds, tree, John, cross, alive

🔗 Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book		Picture / Summary
1. Matthew		A. 🤗 Doctor's careful account; shepherds, Zacchaeus, the Lost Son; "seek and save the lost"
2. Mark		B. ❤️ Seven signs and seven "I AM"s; John 3:16; Thomas: "My Lord and my God!"
3. Luke		C. 👑 Wise men; Sermon on the Mount; "Go and make disciples"
4. John		D. 🏃 Shortest and fastest; "Immediately!"; "Quiet! Be still!"; came to serve

Answer key: 1–C, 2–D, 3–A, 4–B

Bonus match: Prophecy → Fulfillment (Trailblazers & Ambassadors)

Old Testament promise		Fulfilled in…
1. Micah 5:2 (Bethlehem)		A. Mark 1:2–4 (John the Baptist)
2. Malachi 3:1 (the messenger)		B. Matthew 21:1–9 (Palm Sunday)
3. Zechariah 9:9 (King on a donkey)		C. Matthew 2:1–6 (born in Bethlehem)
4. Isaiah 53:5 (pierced for our sins)		D. Matthew 12:40 & 28:6 (three days, then risen)
5. Jonah 1:17 (three days in the fish)		E. John 19:34–37 (the cross)

Answer key: 1–C, 2–A, 3–B, 4–E, 5–D

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Who is Jesus? (God's Son, the King, my Savior!)
2. How does Jesus feel about you? (He loves me!)
3. Who could you tell about Jesus?
4. What can you do when you're scared, like in a storm? (Pray to Jesus!)
5. Is Jesus alive today? (Yes!)

Explorers (7–10)

1. Which Gospel story is your favorite? Why?
2. The four friends helped their friend get to Jesus. How can you help a friend know Jesus?
3. Zacchaeus changed after he met Jesus. How does knowing Jesus change how we act?
4. Why do you think Jesus was willing to die on the cross?
5. What does it mean to "believe" in Jesus?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God gave us four Gospels instead of one?

2. Which Old Testament promise fulfilled by Jesus amazes you the most?
3. Thomas had doubts. What questions do you have about Jesus, and who can you ask?
4. What does it look like to be a disciple (follower) of Jesus in middle school?
5. Jesus came to serve (Mark 10:45). Where could you serve this week?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. If a friend asked, "Who is Jesus to you?", what would you say?
2. How do the four Gospels' different emphases (King, Servant, Savior, Son) help you understand Jesus more fully?
3. What part of Jesus' teaching (e.g., the Sermon on the Mount) is hardest for you to live out?
4. How does the resurrection change how you think about the future, death or failure?
5. What would it look like for you to obey the Great Commission this year?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. "How do we know the Gospels are reliable and not legends?" *Suggested answer:* (a) **Early:** The Gospels were most likely written within 20–65 years of Jesus' death, while eyewitnesses and opponents were still alive; Paul's letters (some from the A.D. 50s) quote even earlier creeds about Jesus' death and resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:3–8). (b) **Eyewitness-based:** Luke says he investigated eyewitness testimony (Luke 1:1–4); John claims to be an eyewitness (John 21:24). (c) **Well-preserved:** We have thousands of Greek New Testament manuscripts, some fragments within about a century of writing, far more than for any other ancient work. (d) **Historically accurate details:** Places, rulers and customs (e.g., Pilate, Caiaphas, the Pool of Bethesda) have been confirmed by archaeology. (e) **Embarrassing details:** The disciples look slow and fearful, and women are the first witnesses. Inventors of a legend wouldn't have written it that way.

2. "Didn't the Gospels contradict each other?" *Suggested answer:* The Gospels have differences in detail and emphasis (like how many angels were at the tomb: Matthew mentions one, Luke two). Different eyewitness accounts typically vary this way. If one mentions two angels, there was certainly at least one! Courts expect independent witnesses to agree on the core and differ on details; identical accounts would suggest copying or collusion. All four agree on the central facts: Jesus' ministry, crucifixion under Pilate, burial, empty tomb and resurrection appearances.

3. "Did Jesus really rise from the dead, or is there another explanation?" *Suggested answer:* Historians, including many skeptical ones, widely accept several facts: Jesus died by crucifixion; His followers sincerely believed they saw Him alive; the persecutor Paul and the skeptic James (Jesus' brother) were converted by what they believed were appearances; and the tomb was found empty. Alternative theories struggle: hallucinations don't happen to groups of 500 at once (1 Cor. 15:6); a stolen body doesn't explain the disciples' willingness to suffer for their claim; "swoon theory" ignores Roman execution expertise. The resurrection best explains the evidence, and it is the foundation of Christian faith (1 Corinthians 15:14, 17, 20).

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday): "Good News Party"

1. **Welcome (10 min):** Sing all six verses of the Library Song (including the whispered Bridge), then sing Verse 6 as a round.
2. **43-Book Challenge (5 min):** Classes try to beat their best time.
3. **Gospel Four Corners (10 min):** Games #1.
4. **Fishers of People Net Tag (10 min):** Games #6.
5. **Gospel Bracelets (10 min):** Activities #5. Ambassadors help Little Lambs.
6. **Oral check-offs (15 min):** Use the checklists below.
7. **Passport & badge ceremony (15 min):** Stamp passports, award badges and certificates. Close with a resurrection celebration (a sunrise-yellow cupcake or donut "empty tomb," a donut hole!) and prayer.

✅ Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6)

- [ ] Says "Gospel means Good News"
- [ ] Says the four Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John) with motions; at least 3 counts!
- [ ] Says the Little Lambs verse: "For God so loved the world."
- [ ] Tells one Jesus story in a sentence (e.g., "Jesus calmed the storm" or "Jesus is alive!")

Explorers (7–10)

- [ ] Says all 4 Gospels in order
- [ ] Spells all 4 correctly (MATTHEW, MARK, LUKE, JOHN)
- [ ] Says John 3:16 from memory
- [ ] Sings the Library Song (all 6 verses)

Trailblazers (11–13)

- [ ] Says all 43 books so far in order (no song)
- [ ] Gives each Gospel's "one word" and one key story
- [ ] Says John 3:16 from memory
- [ ] Names three Old Testament prophecies Jesus fulfilled

Ambassadors (14–17)

- [ ] Says all 43 books so far in order
- [ ] Says John 3:16 and explains it in their own words
- [ ] Teaches one Gospel (story + motion + spelling) to a younger child
- [ ] Explains the gospel using the ABC outline or the Gospel Bracelet

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Open the **New Testament** section of the passport for the first time! Stamp the **Gospels** page with a gold cross-and-sunrise stamp. Kids write or trace: "I know 43 of 66 books! I met Jesus!"

🏅 Badge: "I Met Jesus!"

A round sunrise-gold badge with an empty cross in front of a rising sun. In the four "corners" around the circle: a crown (Matthew), running sandals (Mark), open arms (Luke) and a heart (John). Banner: "GOSPELS · 4 BOOKS · GOOD NEWS!"

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School "I Met Jesus!" Gospel Certificate**
>
> This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 9: Meet Jesus!** and has learned the four Gospels: **Matthew · Mark · Luke · John**
>
> "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16)
>
> **Books learned: 43 of 66** Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy or print this section and send it home.*

Dear Families,

This month we crossed the bridge into the **New Testament** and met **Jesus** in the four Gospels: **Matthew, Mark, Luke and John**. "Gospel" means "Good News"! Matthew shows Jesus as the promised **King**, Mark as the mighty **Servant**, Luke as the **Savior for everyone**, and John as **God's Son** who gives eternal life to all who believe. We learned about the wise men, the friends who lowered a man through a roof, Jesus calming the storm, Zacchaeus in the tree, and most importantly that Jesus died on the cross for our sins and **rose again**! Your child now knows **43 of the 66 books** of the Bible.

Your child may have questions about following Jesus. That's wonderful! If they do, we'd love to help. Please feel free to talk with your child's teacher or our children's ministry leader.

📖 **Memory Verse:**

> "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16, NIV)

> *Little Lambs:* "For God so loved the world."

🎵 **This month's song verse (tune: "Frère Jacques," each line twice):**

> Mat-thew, Mark, Luke, *(Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,)* Then comes John! *(Then comes John!)* Tell-ing us of Je-sus, *(Tell-ing us of Je-sus,)* Good News: FOUR! *(Good News: FOUR!)*

(Try singing it as a round at dinner!)

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. Which Jesus story did you learn this month? What did Jesus do?
2. Zacchaeus changed after meeting Jesus. How does Jesus change people today?
3. What does John 3:16 tell us about how much God loves us?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Four Gospels, Four Nights"** Pick four nights this week. Each night, read one short story from a different Gospel together:

- **Night 1, Matthew 2:1–12:** The wise men (put a flashlight "star" on the ceiling!)
- **Night 2, Mark 4:35–41:** Jesus calms the storm (read it in the bathtub or by a bowl of water!)
- **Night 3, Luke 19:1–10:** Zacchaeus (eat dinner "at Zacchaeus's house," with a picnic under a tree or houseplant)
- **Night 4, John 20:1–18:** The empty tomb (open an empty box or plastic egg together and say "He is risen!")

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **Sharefaith Kids:** "Wise Men," "Jesus Calms the Storm," "Zacchaeus," "Easter": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jesus
- **Bible Journey:** "Matthew," "Luke," "Resurrection": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jesus
- **BibleProject (older kids & parents):** "Overview: Matthew 1-13," "Overview: Matthew 14-28," "Overview: Mark," "Overview: Luke 1-9," "Overview: Luke 10-24," "Overview: John 1-12," "Overview: John 13-21," and the theme video "Gospel of the Kingdom": https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Matthew

Next month: *The Church Is Born!* The book of Acts, with the Holy Spirit, Peter, and Paul's amazing journeys!